the Earth's atmosphere and are attracted by the gravitational force of Earth. Most of them are burnt up by the heat generated due to friction in the Earth's atmosphere. They are called meteors. Some of the bigger meteors may not be burnt completely and they fall on the surface of Earth. These are called meteorites.

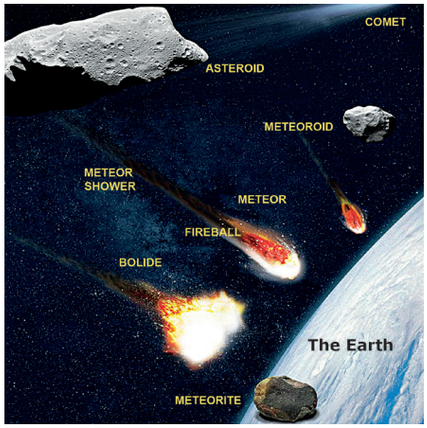


Figure 9.4 Meteors and Meteorites

Satellites

A body moving in an orbit around a planet is called satellite. In order to distinguish them from the man made satellites (called as artificial satellites), they are called as natural satellites or moons. Satellite of the Earth is called Moon (other satellites are written as moon). We can see the Earth's satellite Moon, because it reflects the light of the Sun. Satellite moves around the planets due to gravity, and the centripetal force. Among the planets in the solar system all the planets have moons except Mercury and Venus.

DO YOU KNOW?

The Sun travelling at a speed of 250 km per second (9 lakh km/h) takes about 225 million years to complete one revolution around the Milky Way. This period is called a cosmic year.

9.3 Orbital Velocity

We saw that there are natural satellites moving around the planets. There will be gravitational force between the planet and satellites. Nowadays many artificial satellites are launched into the Earth's orbit. The first artificial satellite Sputnik was launched in 1956. India launched its first satellite Aryabhatta on April 19, 1975. Artificial satellites are made to revolve in an orbit at a height of few hundred kilometres. At this altitude, the friction due to air is negligible. The satellite is carried by a rocket to the desired height and released horizontally with a high velocity, so that it remains moving in a nearly circular orbit.

The horizontal velocity that has to be imparted to a satellite at the determined height so that it makes a circular orbit around the planet is called orbital velocity.

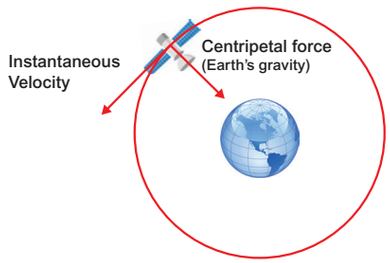


Figure 9.5 Orbital velocity

The orbital velocity of the satellite depends on its altitude above Earth. Nearer the object to the Earth, the faster is the required orbital velocity. At an altitude of 200 kilometres, the required orbital velocity is little more than 27,400 kph. That orbital speed and distance permit the satellite to make one revolution in 24 hours. Since Earth also rotates once in 24 hours, a satellite stays in a fixed position relative to a point on Earth's surface. Because the satellite stays over the same spot all the time, this kind of orbit is called 'geostationary'. Orbital velocity can be calculated using the following formula.

$$v = \sqrt{\frac{GM}{(R+h)}}$$ where,

G = Gravitational constant (6.673×10^{-11} Nm^2kg^{-2})

M = Mass of the Earth (5.972×10^{24} kg)

R = Radius of the Earth (6371 km)

h = Height of the satellite from the surface of the Earth.

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